Key question
Why and how did the superpowers become involved?

The superpowers intervene

The USA and the USSR were deeply involved in the Yom Kippur War. The USSR sent arms to Egypt and Syria and the USA organised a massive airlift to Israel. When the Israelis crossed the Suez Canal both superpowers stepped in. The Soviet government advised Egypt to accept a ceasefire while it still held part of Sinai. The US government, for its part, was worried by the Arab oil weapon, but even more by the threat of armed intervention by Soviet troops. For a time, American forces were put on nuclear alert.

Both superpowers were keen to avoid a direct confrontation. The USA prevented its Israeli ally from advancing on either Cairo or Damascus, the Syrian capital. American and Soviet leaders met and together demanded a ceasefire which the UN supported. The fighting ended on 24 October. A few days later UN troops were sent to Egypt to preserve the ceasefire.

Key question
To what extent was the war an Arab victory?

The results of the war

The Yom Kippur War was, in the end, a military victory for the Israelis. Yet again they had proved that their weapons, their training and their tactics were superior. But they had incurred far more losses, of both men and weaponry, than in previous wars. Perhaps most significant, the Arabs had destroyed the myth of Israeli invincibility. They had completely surprised the Israelis and the rest of the world with their attack. They had proved that Arab soldiers could fight with courage and determination under skilled leaders. Above all, they had acted together, both in their military planning and in the use of the oil weapon. As a result the rest of the world showed much more respect for the Arabs.

One man, in particular, emerged from the war as a world leader. Anwar Sadat had achieved exactly what he had set out to do. First, he had broken the stalemate that existed before the war. Secondly, he had forced a change in US policy. From now on, the USA was to become far more friendly towards the Arab states and far more willing to persuade Israel to enter peace negotiations.

Key question
What steps led to an Israeli–Egyptian peace treaty?

President Sadat and the Israeli–Egyptian peace treaty

For the next two years, from 1973 to 1975, the US Secretary of State, Henry Kissinger, engaged in 'shuttle diplomacy': he shuttled back and forth between the Israeli, Egyptian and Syrian capitals in order to arrange treaties of 'disengagement'. In 1974–5 he secured a series of agreements by which Israeli forces would withdraw from the Suez Canal area and from part of the Golan Heights. The agreement on Suez enabled Egypt to clear the Canal, which was reopened in 1975, and to start rebuilding the cities along the Canal which had been devastated by Israeli shelling from 1968 to 1970. Saudi Arabia started selling oil to the USA again.